

Dealing with a Difficult Manager

Protecting yourself and moving forward, without burning out

4 psychology approaches · tips & advice — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Protecting yourself and moving forward, without burning out

An authoritarian, unpredictable manager who micromanages or never acknowledges anything: hard to do good work. Without being able to change them, you can learn to cope, protect yourself, and keep your energy.

This guide helps you understand what it stirs in you, protect your self-esteem, and adopt concrete strategies. (If it turns into repeated disrespect or degradation, see the 'psychological harassment' guide.)

Your intention

What's hardest with your manager: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

What it stirs in you

A difficult manager can wake old authority figures (a demanding parent, an unfair teacher) and a strong need for recognition. Your reactions also say something about your history.

Seeing it helps you respond to the present situation, not your past.

Example

His boss's remarks took Sami back to a never-satisfied father. Understanding it defused part of his emotional load.

What it stirs

Whom or what does your manager remind you of? Which emotion dominates?

Present vs past

In your reaction, what responds to the present / what comes from further back?

→ *I respond to the present situation — not my history.*

The thoughts that amplify

'They have it in for me personally', 'I'm never good enough': these mind-readings add suffering to an already hard situation.

Softening them gives you back room to maneuver.

Example

Sure she was 'targeted', Inès noticed her manager was harsh with everyone. It put her experience in perspective.

Situations journal

Note: the situation · my thought ('they have it in for me...') · another possible explanation.

Reframe

Turn 'I'm never good enough' into verifiable facts about your work.

→ *Not everything is personal — I check before absorbing it.*

Protecting your self-esteem

Don't let a difficult manager define your worth. Separate professional from personal: clumsy or unfair feedback doesn't erase your skills.

Your self-esteem isn't negotiated with every mood of your boss.

Example

Leaning on her wins and feedback from other colleagues, Léa stopped letting her manager dictate her self-esteem.

My worth, beyond their gaze

Write 5 truths about your skills, independent of your manager.

Separate pro & personal

For a criticism received: what's a useful professional point / what's just their tone?

→ *Unfair feedback doesn't erase my skills.*

Concrete strategies

Coping concretely: understand your manager's workings (priorities, stress), adapt your communication (written, factual, anticipation), frame expectations, choose your battles, and lean on allies.

And recognize the limit: if 'difficult' becomes repeated disrespect or degradation, it's harassment — other channels exist.

Example

By anticipating in writing what her unpredictable manager needed, Sofia reduced tension and regained calm.

Understand & adapt

Note: what stresses or matters to your manager · how to adapt your communication accordingly.

My allies & my limit

List 1-2 allies, and write your limit (at what point you involve HR / a channel).

→ *Understand, adapt, build support — without absorbing it all.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- Understand their workings (priorities, stress, expectations).
- Adapt your communication: factual, in writing, anticipate their needs.
- Frame expectations in writing (who does what, by when).
- Choose your battles and document important exchanges.
- Lean on allies; protect your energy outside work.
- If it turns into repeated disrespect or degradation → see the 'psychological harassment' guide.

To fill in

Situations journal

The situation	My thought	Another explanation

Understand my manager

What matters/stresses them	How I adapt

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — See what it stirs in me.

Week 2 — Soften the thoughts that amplify.

Week 3 — Protect my self-esteem.

Week 4 — Concrete strategies & my limit.

Your plan in 3 lines

- What I choose to stop taking personally:
- How I adapt my communication:
- My limit (when I involve a channel):

TO CLOSE

Coping without burning out — your worth stays intact.

Coping without burning out — your worth stays intact.

This guide is a coaching and psychoeducation tool, not a substitute for therapy. If you are going through a hard time, please reach out to a professional or a crisis line in your country. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.